

Till he got shingles last year, Pune-based Sohil Kapadia had never even heard of the disease. At 68, the retired bank manager was a healthy person with no history of any other illness. He had never experienced anything so debilitating—not even Covid. "It was like my whole body was on fire," says Kapadia. "For six months, I couldn't even feed myself because of the severe ache in my nerves." What worries him more is that even after this episode, he could still get shingles all over again.

A viral infection, shingles is caused by the varicella-zoster virus—the same virus that causes chickenpox. "After you have had chickenpox, the virus stays in the body for the rest of your life," explains Dr Sandeep Budhiraja, medical director, Max Healthcare, "and years later, it can reactivate and travel around your nerve pathways to the skin, causing a painful rash that usually looks like a stripe of blisters around the right or left side of your torso." That's how shingles, medically known as herpes zoster, gets its colloquial names in India: Nagin, Brahmsutri and Janeu.

According to a study published in the journal *Indian Pediatrics* in 2000, 90 per cent of Indians above the age of 40 carry the varicella-zoster virus, putting them at risk of contracting the disease. According to global estimates, every third person carrying the virus usually gets shingles in their lifetime. The reason shingles is a public health concern is not the disease itself, but the later complications—burning pain in nerves and skin even after the rashes fade, known as post-herpetic neuralgia (PHN)—that can greatly impact the quality and longevity of life. Per the US-based Centers for Disease Control and Prevention (CDC), shingles typically occurs in those aged above 50, with the 60-plus patients at a 30 per cent higher risk of developing PHN. There is no direct cure, and treatment is mainly symptomatic, that is, it addresses only the symptoms and not the underlying cause.

Hope surfaced this year in April, when GlaxoSmithKline Pharmaceuticals Ltd launched Shingrix (or Zoster Vaccine Recombinant, Adjuvanted) in India—six years after it was first introduced in the US—for the prevention of shingles and PHN in people aged 50 and above. Available for Rs 7,500 to Rs 10,999 per dose (depending on the discount you get), it has to be injected intramuscularly in two doses within the space of two to six months. Actor Amitabh Bachchan has been brought on board to raise awareness, given

90%
INDIANS ABOVE THE AGE OF 40 CARRY THE VIRUS THAT CAUSES SHINGLES

72%
PATIENTS IN A SURVEY DIDN'T KNOW WHAT SHINGLES WAS BEFORE THEY GOT IT

97%
VACCINE'S EFFICACY IN PREVENTING SHINGLES IN 50-69 AGE GROUP